



IPCop

Firewall for SMEs

Here's the success story of a firewall implementation that helped an SME meet its client's requirements without spending on unnecessary software baggage.

Today, nobody can live without conducting business activities on the Internet. The activities could be as simple as sending e-mails, browsing Web pages, earning revenue through e-commerce and e-governance. In all these cases, firewalls are the first line of defence. The type of firewall could range from a simple piece of software on a personal computer system (personal firewall), to fully-redundant, load-balancing firewalls that have to function at high speed to cope with the workload.

A typical firewall consists of a combination of hardware and software in the form of an appliance. Firewalls are widely used in the enterprise segment to enforce security policies and access controls. Although the SME segment values the utility of firewalls, its cost is a major deterrent to implementation. This brings us to a firewall for SMEs—IPCop.

Allow me to share the story of an SME working in the area of computer-aided design and catering to a small number of international clients.

Background check

One of the company's important customers had put in an additional security clause in the work agreement at the time of renewal. To satisfy the requirement, purchase of a firewall was necessary. At the time, due to the global meltdown, immediately financing a commercially-available firewall solution was really difficult. Being managing director of the company, Shree was worried.

Betting on the strength of the Internet, Shree turned to Google and found a number of Linux-based freely available firewall distros. After consulting Kedar, a friend who was a networking expert, he decided to implement the IPCop firewall to satisfy his customer requirements. On the Web, IPCop was praised as stable, easy to configure and flexible, and it was possible to install it on an old PC with a minimum of two Ethernet cards.

The security requirements given by the client for the PCs allotted to its work are detailed below:

- No connectivity to other PCs in the company
- Internet access only to the customer vault